

# Executive Summary

This week’s article focuses on Business Requirements as the starting point of every effective Power BI solution. It explains how analysts can move from understanding business drivers to defining clear reporting needs, translating them into functional requirements, and mapping them to relevant Power BI features. The goal is to show that strong reports are not built by starting with visuals, but by first understanding the decision the report needs to support.

## Key Highlights

- **Business Drivers:** Good Power BI work starts by understanding the business problem, not the visual.
- **Requirement Translation:** Business needs must be converted into functional reporting requirements.
- **Power BI Mapping:** Each requirement should connect to a specific Power BI feature or design decision.
- **Decision Focus:** The goal is not to build charts, but to make data usable for decisions.

## Business Drivers

### From Business Drivers to Business Requirements

Every Power BI project should begin with one question: **What decision does this report need to support?**

Business requirements are the high-level needs, goals, and problems that the business wants to solve. They explain why a report is needed before deciding what needs to be built. For example, a **business driver** might be: “We need better visibility into monthly sales performance.” That driver can become a **business requirement** such as: “The sales leadership team needs a monthly view of revenue, targets, product performance, and regional trends to identify underperforming areas.”

This step matters because Power BI is not just a dashboarding tool. Microsoft positions the Power BI data analyst role around preparing, modelling, visualizing, analyzing, managing, and securing data to support business insights and decisions.

| Area             | What to Ask                                                                                |
|------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Business problem | What issue are we trying to solve?                                                         |
| Decision need    | What decision will this report support?                                                    |
| Audience         | Who will use the report? Executives, managers, analysts, operations teams?                 |
| KPIs             | What metrics matter most?                                                                  |
| Frequency        | Is this daily, weekly, monthly, real-time, or ad hoc?                                      |
| Granularity      | Do users need summary, department, region, product, customer, or transaction-level detail? |
| Actions          | What should users do after seeing the insight?                                             |

Fig: A good requirement-gathering process usually captures.

### Further Reading:

- BI strategy Overview: [Link](#)
- BI Strategic Planning: [Link](#)
- BI Tactical Planning: [Link](#)
- BI Solution Planning: [Link](#)
- Power BI implementation planning: [Link](#) ( The series focuses on planning to implement a Power BI experience inside Microsoft Fabric.)

## Requirement Translation

## From Business Requirement to Functional Requirement

Once the business requirement is clear, the next step is to translate it into functional requirements. A business requirement explains the business need. A functional requirement explains what the Power BI solution must do to meet that need.

| Business Requirement                                               | Functional Requirement                                                               |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Sales managers need to monitor revenue performance across regions. | Create a regional sales dashboard with revenue, target, variance, and trend visuals. |
| Executives need a quick view of business health.                   | Build KPI cards showing revenue, margin, customer growth, and target achievement.    |
| Operations teams need to identify problem areas quickly.           | Add filters, slicers, drill-through pages, and conditional formatting.               |
| Different managers should only see their own region.               | Apply row-level security based on user role or region.                               |

Fig: What Business Wants to What Power BI needs to Deliver

### Requirement Translation Framework



Fig: A simple Requirement Transition Framework.

Further Readings:

- Content Lifecycle Management : [LINK](#)
- Plan and Design Content : [LINK](#)
- Develop and Manage Content : [LINK](#)
- Validate Content : [LINK](#)
- Deploy Content : [LINK](#)
- Support and Monitor Content : [LINK](#)

## Power BI Mapping

This is the practical bridge between requirements and development.

- **“Before I build anything, how do I know what the report is actually supposed to answer?” Power BI focus:** Requirement planning: define business questions, users, KPIs, success measures, and report scope. **Reference:** [Guidance documentation - Power BI | Microsoft Learn](#)
- **“My stakeholder’s data is spread across Excel files, databases, SharePoint folders, and online systems. How do I bring these sources into one reporting solution?” Power BI focus:** Get Data and connectors: connect to files, databases, web sources, and business systems. **Reference:** [Data sources in Power BI Desktop - Power BI | Microsoft Learn](#)

- **“The business needs both historical reporting and up-to-date operational visibility. How do I decide whether the data should be stored in Power BI or queried from the source?”** Power BI focus: Storage and connection modes: use Import, DirectQuery, live connection, or composite models. Reference: [DirectQuery in Power BI: When to Use, Limitations, Alternatives - Power BI | Microsoft Learn](#)
- **“The source data has inconsistent formats, missing values, duplicate records, and columns that are not analysis-ready. How do I prepare it before reporting?”** Power BI focus: Power Query Editor: clean, transform, merge, append, and shape data. Reference: [Query Overview in Power BI Desktop - Power BI | Microsoft Learn](#)
- **“The report needs to show sales by product, customer, region, and time without creating confusing or duplicated calculations. How should the data structure be designed?”** Power BI focus: Data modelling: design fact tables, dimension tables, and star schema. Reference: [Understand star schema and the importance for Power BI - Power BI | Microsoft Learn](#)
- **“Different tables hold related business information, but the report needs them to work together correctly when users filter the data. How do I control that behaviour?”** Power BI focus: Relationships: manage cardinality, cross-filter direction, and active/inactive relationships. Reference: [Model relationships in Power BI Desktop - Power BI | Microsoft Learn](#)
- **“The business wants metrics like profit margin, variance, year-on-year growth, and target achievement instead of just raw columns. How do I create reusable business logic?”** Power BI focus: DAX measures: build reusable calculations that respond to report filters. Reference: [Measures in Power BI Desktop - Power BI | Microsoft Learn](#)
- **“Executives want a quick view, managers want comparisons, and analysts want detail. How do I choose visuals that match each user’s decision need?”** Power BI focus: Power BI visuals: use cards, KPIs, charts, matrices, slicers, and filters. Reference: [Overview of visualizations in Power BI - Power BI | Microsoft Learn](#)
- **“Users need to start from a summary page but investigate specific regions, products, or records when something looks unusual. How do I support that flow?”** Power BI focus: Drill-through and tooltips: guide users from summary views to detail. Reference: [Drillthrough in Power BI Reports: Navigate to Detailed Insights - Power BI | Microsoft Learn](#)
- **“The report should guide users through the story instead of leaving them to click around randomly. How do I create a more structured experience?”** Power BI focus: Interactive storytelling: use bookmarks, buttons, navigators, slicers, and cross-filtering. Reference: [Create Page and Bookmark Navigators - Power BI | Microsoft Learn](#)
- **“Leadership can see that a KPI has changed, but they also want to understand what might be driving the change. How do I support deeper analysis?”** Power BI focus: Advanced analytics: use Key Influencers, Decomposition Tree, Q&A, and AI visuals. Reference: [Key Influencers Visualizations Tutorial - Power BI | Microsoft Learn](#)
- **“The report is useful, but users are frustrated because pages load slowly and refresh takes too long. How do I improve the experience?”** Power BI focus: Performance tuning: use Performance Analyzer, model optimization, and refresh planning. Reference: [Use Performance Analyzer to Examine Report Performance - Power BI | Microsoft Learn](#)
- **“Different teams need access to the same report, but not everyone should see the same level of data. How do I manage access properly?”** Power BI focus: Security and

governance: use workspace roles, app permissions, RLS, and sensitivity labels. **Reference:** [Row-level security \(RLS\) guidance in Power BI Desktop - Power BI | Microsoft Learn](#)

- **“The dashboard has been built, but how do we make sure it becomes a trusted reporting asset rather than a one-time file?”** **Power BI focus:** Decision systems: publish apps, reuse semantic models, monitor refresh, and support adoption. **Reference:** [What is Power BI? - Power BI | Microsoft Learn](#)

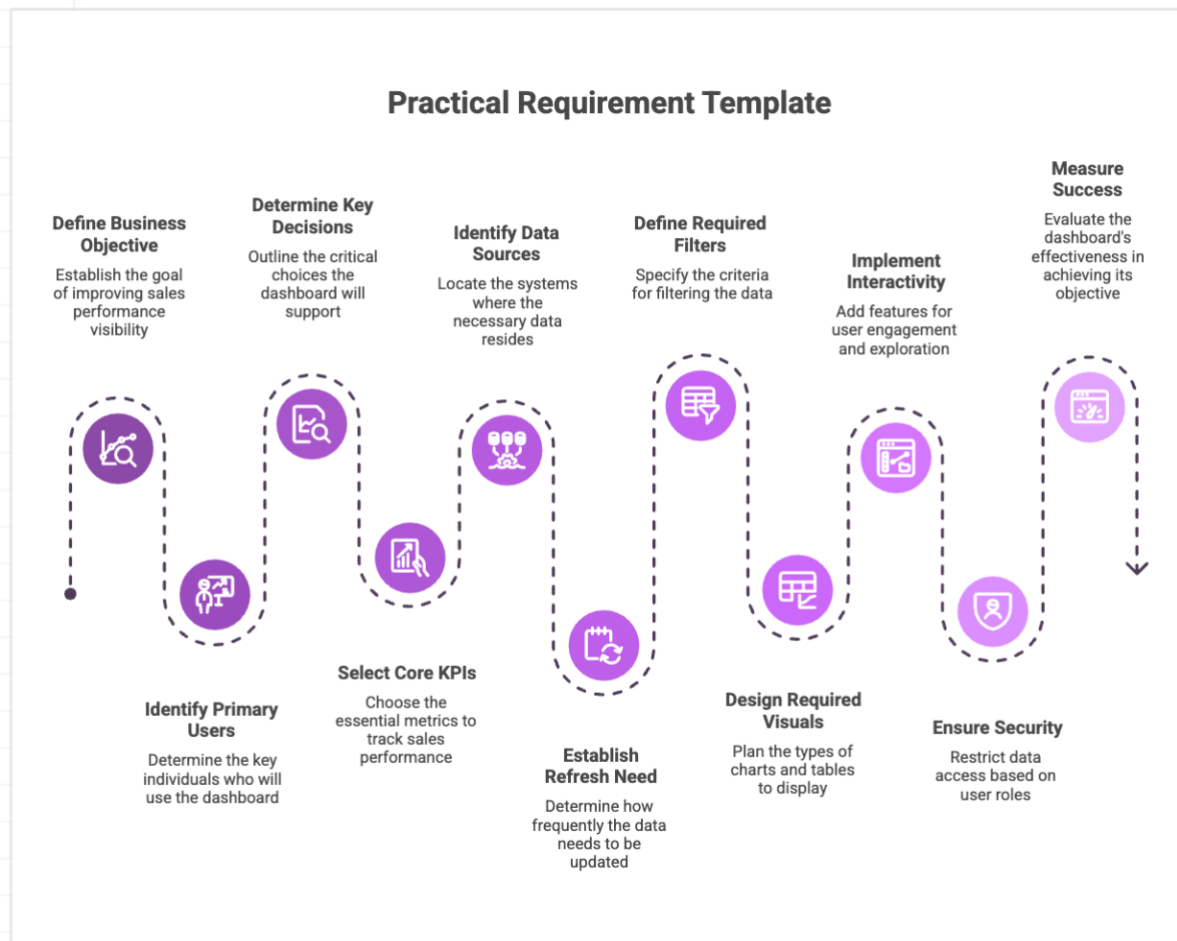


Fig: Decision Focus, Example of performance dashboard development.

## Conclusion

Business requirements give direction to the entire Power BI workflow. When analysts clearly understand the business problem, users, KPIs, and decision needs, they can design reports that are more relevant, usable, and action-focused. The job is not just “make charts.” The job is to make data usable for decisions.

Stay tuned for next week’s article in [The Insight Stack](#) : Power BI, Layer by Layer, where we move into Week 2: Data Connection and explore how analysts identify, access, and connect to the right data sources before building the report.